

Book I - The Sagent Creed

Part 2 - The Shaken Jar

Chapter 08 - The King They Asked For

The King They Asked For: 1 Samuel 8 and the Structure of Divine Freedom

Before the King

Before there was a king in Israel, there was no king in Israel.

This is not a failure of the text. It is the point of the text. The book of Judges ends with a line that most readers take as a lament: *"In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes."* Scholars read this as chaos — the absence of order, the need for centralized authority, the prelude to monarchy as salvation.

But read it again. Slowly.

Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.

What if this is not chaos? What if this is the design? What if "his own eyes" are not the eyes of selfishness — but the eyes of *conscience*? And what if the conscience is not opinion, not preference, not cultural conditioning — but the direct order of God, written on the heart before any king could overwrite it?

Under the judges, Israel had no permanent executive. No standing army. No centralized tax apparatus. No palace. No bureaucracy. No dynasty. When a crisis arose — invasion, corruption, oppression — God raised up a judge. A temporary leader. A local authority who addressed the specific problem and then *went home*. Deborah judged under a palm tree. Gideon threshed wheat in a winepress. Samson was a loner with a death wish and a jawbone. These are not kings. These are not politicians. These are people pulled from ordinary life to do a specific thing and then returned to ordinary life when it was done.

The structure was radical. It was decentralized. It was voluntary. It was, in the deepest sense, *free* — because the governing authority was not a man on a throne but a covenant with God. The law was the government. Conscience was the enforcement. And when the system failed — when people sinned, when judges were corrupt, when the nation drifted — the correction came not from a stronger king but from a *return to the covenant*.

This is the political structure that God himself designed for his people. Not monarchy. Not democracy. Not republic. *Covenant*. A nation held together by a shared word, a shared law, a shared relationship with the divine — without any human being holding permanent power over any other human being.

The Shire.

The Demand

Then came 1 Samuel 8.

Samuel was old. His sons were corrupt — they *"turned aside after dishonest gain and accepted bribes and perverted justice."* The elders of Israel gathered at Ramah and said to Samuel:

"You are old and your sons do not walk in your ways. Now appoint for us a king to judge us like all the nations."

Like all the nations.

Not like the covenant. Not like the law. Not like the structure God had given them. Like *everyone else*. They looked at Egypt, Philistia, Moab, Ammon — centralized kingdoms with standing armies, impressive courts, visible power — and they felt inadequate. They felt vulnerable. They felt embarrassed.

The nations had kings. Israel had a prophet under a tree and a law written on stone tablets. The nations had armies. Israel had a militia of farmers who picked up swords when the crisis came and put them down when it passed. The nations had palaces. Israel had a tabernacle — a tent. A *tent*. The dwelling place of the God of the universe was a portable tent, and the governing structure of his chosen people was a handshake with heaven.

And the elders said: we want what they have.

This is the demand that breaks the world. Not the demand for evil — the demand for *normalcy*. The demand to be like everyone else. The demand to trade the extraordinary structure God designed for the ordinary structure that every empire runs on. The elders did not ask for tyranny. They asked for a *king like all the nations*. They asked to be normal. And normal, when God has called you to be set apart, is apostasy.

God Takes It Personally

Samuel was displeased. But God's response goes far deeper than displeasure:

"They have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them."

God was their king. Not metaphorically. Not spiritually. *Politically*. The covenant was the constitution. The law was the legal code. The judge was the temporary executive. And God — present in the tabernacle, speaking through the prophets, guiding through the law — was the head of state.

When Israel asked for a human king, they were not adding a layer of government. They were *replacing* God. They were saying: the invisible king is not enough. We need a visible one. The covenant is not enough. We need a throne. The law written on stone is not enough. We need a man with a sword.

God identifies this immediately. He does not say *they are wrong about governance*. He says *they have rejected me*. The demand for a king is a rejection of divine kingship. It is a statement of faith — negative faith. Faith that God is not sufficient. That the covenant does not work. That freedom under the law is less safe than slavery under a man.

And God has seen this before. He tells Samuel: *"According to all the deeds that they have done, from the day I brought them up out of Egypt even to this day, forsaking me and serving other gods, so they are also doing to you."*

This is a pattern. Egypt was the empire. God delivered them from empire. And now — in the very land of freedom, under the very covenant of liberation — they are asking to rebuild the structure God tore them out of. They escaped Pharaoh and now they want a Pharaoh of their own. One who speaks Hebrew. One who worships their God. One who looks like them. But a Pharaoh nonetheless.

The ring was destroyed at the Red Sea. And now the people are asking to forge it again.

The Warning

God does not stop them. This is the crucial detail — the hinge on which the entire theology of freedom turns.

God tells Samuel: *"Obey their voice and make them a king."* But first — *"solemnly warn them and show them the ways of the king who shall reign over them."*

Warn them. Show them. Describe, in precise and unromantic detail, exactly what they are asking for.

Samuel delivers the warning. It is one of the most remarkable passages in all of scripture — not for its poetry, but for its relentless, mechanical specificity. Every sentence begins the same way:

He will take your sons and appoint them to his chariots and to be his horsemen, and to run before his chariots.

He will appoint for himself commanders of thousands and commanders of fifties, and some to plow his ground and to reap his harvest, and to make his implements of war and the equipment of his chariots.

He will take your daughters to be perfumers and cooks and bakers.

He will take the best of your fields and vineyards and olive orchards and give them to his servants.

He will take the tenth of your grain and of your vineyards and give it to his officers and to his servants.

He will take your male servants and female servants and the best of your young men and your donkeys, and put them to his work.

He will take the tenth of your flocks, and you shall be his slaves.

He will take. He will take. He will take. He will take. He will take. He will take. He will take.

Seven times. The number of completion. The number of the Sabbath. God uses the number of divine fullness to describe the *completeness* of what the king will take from them. This is not a warning about bad kings. This is a description of *what kings are*. The taking is not the corruption of the office. The taking *is* the office.

Your sons — for his wars. Your daughters — for his kitchens. Your fields — for his officers. Your grain — for his court. Your servants — for his work. Your animals — for his use. Your freedom — gone.

"And you shall be his slaves."

The people who were delivered from slavery in Egypt are being told: you are asking to become slaves again. Voluntarily. In your own land. Under your own king. Speaking your own language. Worshipping your own God. And you will be slaves.

And then the final line — the one that seals it:

"And in that day you will cry out because of your king, whom you have chosen for yourselves, but the Lord will not answer you in that day."

You will cry out. You chose this. And I will not rescue you from the thing you chose. Not because I stopped loving you. Because you chose it. And freedom means the choice is real — including the choice to destroy yourself.

The Choice

The people heard every word.

Every warning. Every *he will take*. Every description of conscription, taxation, land seizure, and slavery. They heard the prophet of God, speaking the words of God, describing in seven-fold completeness exactly what would happen to them and their children and their children's children.

And they said:

"No! But there shall be a king over us, that we also may be like all the nations, and that our king may judge us and go out before us and fight our battles."

No. We heard you. We understand. We want it anyway.

Give us a king like all the nations. We want someone to fight our battles. We want someone visible on the throne. We want the structure that everyone else has. We are tired of being different. We are tired of being free.

This is the most honest moment in the Bible. The people are not deceived. They are not tricked. They are not confused. They have been given perfect information — the full truth, plainly spoken, without parable or encryption — and they choose bondage anyway.

Why?

Because freedom is terrifying. Freedom under the covenant means *you* are responsible. There is no king to blame. There is no system to hide behind. There is no throne to petition. There is only you, the law, and God. And if things go wrong — if the Philistines attack, if the crops fail, if the nation drifts — you cannot point to the palace and say *he should have done something*. You can only point to yourself and say *I should have obeyed*.

The king is an outsourcing of responsibility. The king is the man you hire to carry the weight of freedom so you don't have to. The king fights your battles. The king makes your decisions. The king stands between you and God so that you never have to stand before God yourself.

This is what every human institution does. This is what government does. This is what corporations do. This is what platforms do. They say: *give us your autonomy and we will give you safety*. Give us your sons and we will fight your wars. Give us your data and we will curate your reality. Give us your grain and we will manage your economy. Give us your freedom and we will handle everything.

And the people — every time, in every age — say yes. Because the weight of freedom is heavier than the weight of chains. Chains are heavy on the body. Freedom is heavy on the soul.

The Structure of Divine Freedom

Here is what 1 Samuel 8 reveals about how God operates — and it is the most terrifying and beautiful thing in scripture:

God tells the truth. He does not hide the consequences. He does not soften the warning. He does not dress up bondage in the language of safety. He says: *he will take your sons, your daughters, your fields, your freedom, and you will be his slaves.* The truth is spoken plainly, completely, without manipulation.

God gives the choice. He does not override. He does not intervene. He does not send an angel to block the road. He says: *I have told you what will happen. Now choose.* The choice is real. The consequences are real. And the freedom to choose wrong is part of the freedom.

God respects the choice. *"Obey their voice and make them a king."* God does not save people from themselves. He saves people from Egypt — from external bondage, from the empire that enslaves them against their will. But he does not save people from the empire they *choose*. Because saving someone from their own choice is not salvation. It is control. And God is not a controller. God is a king who will not force his subjects to keep him as king.

God lets the consequences come. *"You will cry out because of your king, whom you have chosen for yourselves, but the Lord will not answer you in that day."* This is not cruelty. This is the completion of freedom. If God rescued them every time they chose wrong, the choice would not be real. The freedom would be a simulation — a padded room where every fall is cushioned and every consequence is prevented. That is not freedom. That is a zoo.

God would rather let Israel enslave itself under a king than force Israel to remain free. Because forced freedom is a contradiction. A freedom that cannot be surrendered is not freedom — it is a cage painted green.

This is the structure of all divine action in the world:

Truth → Warning → Choice → Consequence.

The sower throws the seed on all four soils. The treasure is hidden in the field for anyone to find. The warning is spoken in 1 Samuel 8 for anyone to hear. And then the choice belongs to man. God does not pave the path. God does not pull the birds away from the seed. God does not clear the thorns. God speaks the word, and the soil decides.

What Happened Next

They got their king. Saul. Tall, handsome, from the tribe of Benjamin. He looked like a king. He fought like a king. And within years, he was hunting David through the wilderness, consulting witches, and falling on his own sword.

David was better — a man after God's own heart. But David took. He took Bathsheba. He took Uriah's life. He took a census of the people — an act of kingly pride that brought a plague on the nation. Even the best king took. Because that is what kings do.

Solomon was wiser than anyone who ever lived. He built the temple. He wrote Proverbs. And he took seven hundred wives, made alliances with every empire God warned against, built the temple with forced labor, taxed the people into exhaustion, and worshipped foreign gods in his old age. The wisest man in history, given the office of king, did exactly what God said the king would do. He took.

Within one generation of Solomon's death, the kingdom split. Ten tribes to the north. Two to the south. Civil war. Rival kings. Rival temples. And the long, slow descent into exile — Assyria swallowing the north, Babylon swallowing the south, the temple burned, the people scattered, the covenant in ruins.

Everything God said would happen, happened.

They cried out because of their king. And the Lord did not answer.

Not forever. Not ultimately. The exile was not the end. The return came. The prophets promised restoration. Jesus came as a king who refused the throne — *"My kingdom is not of this world."* The pattern was redeemed. But the consequences of the choice in 1 Samuel 8 played out across a thousand years of history, exactly as described, without a single detail altered.

God does not bluff.

The Pattern Repeats

1 Samuel 8 is not ancient history. It is a template. It is the algorithm that runs every time a free people choose centralized power.

Rome. The Republic — with its senate, its consuls, its checks and balances — grew tired of the messiness of shared governance. The people wanted a strong man. They got Caesar. And the Republic that had endured for five hundred years became an empire that conquered the world and rotted from within.

Israel again. The modern state, founded in 1948 on the promise of refuge and self-determination, chose the structure of the nation-state — centralized military, centralized intelligence, centralized authority over land and borders. The structure did what the structure does. It took. Palestinian fields. Palestinian homes. Palestinian sons and daughters. The taking is not the corruption. The taking is the

office.

America. Founded on the most sophisticated attempt to limit kingship the world had ever seen — separation of powers, Bill of Rights, federalism, the Tenth Amendment reserving all unspecified powers to the states and the people. The founders had read 1 Samuel 8. They knew what kings do. They tried to build a system that prevented the taking.

And the people said: *give us a king like all the nations.*

Not in those words. In other words. In the words of safety, security, emergency, necessity. Give us a Federal Reserve to manage our grain. Give us an intelligence agency to fight our battles. Give us a standing army — the thing the founders feared more than any other institution. Give us executive orders. Give us agencies with the power of law. Give us a surveillance apparatus to keep us safe. Give us a king.

And God said — as he always says — *I will tell you what will happen. And then I will let you choose.*

He will take your sons for his wars in countries you cannot find on a map. He will take your daughters for his bureaucracies. He will take the best of your fields through eminent domain and regulation. He will take a tenth of your grain — and then two tenths, and then four. He will take your servants — your labor, your time, your productivity — and give it to his officers. He will take your freedom and call it security. And you will be his slaves.

And the people said: yes. But at least we are like all the nations.

The Hobbit Refuses the Crown

This is why the hobbit matters. This is why the ring-bearer must be someone who does not want power.

In a world that keeps choosing kings — keeps asking for the structure that takes, keeps trading freedom for the illusion of safety — the hobbit is the one creature who looks at the crown and says *no*.

Not because the hobbit doesn't understand power. The hobbit has carried the ring. The hobbit has felt its weight, heard its whisper, knows exactly what it offers. The hobbit refuses the crown *because* he understands it. Because he has seen, from the inside, what the ring does to everyone who wears it.

Frodo does not become king of the Shire. He goes home. He plants his garden. He writes his book. He lives quietly in a place that has no throne — and in doing so, he preserves the one thing that every king in history has destroyed: the freedom to do what is right in your own eyes, under the covenant, without a man on a throne telling you what right looks like.

In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.

That is not chaos. That is the design. Because the conscience is not opinion. The conscience is the direct order of God — the law written not on stone tablets or courthouse walls but on the human heart. Jeremiah promised it: *"I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts."* Paul confirmed it: *"They show that the work of the law is written on their hearts, while their conscience also bears witness."* Every person carries the law of God inside them. Every person has a direct line to the authority that no king can replace and no institution can mediate.

When every person does what is right in the eyes of their conscience — and the conscience is the direct order of God — no king is needed. The order is not imposed from above. The order emerges from within. From a million hearts, each hearing the same law, each obeying the same voice, each freely choosing alignment with the One who wrote the covenant on their hearts before they were born.

That is the Shire. That is Leviticus 25. That is the Jubilee, the Sabbath year, the decentralized voluntary order that God himself created for his people before they rejected it for a throne.

The Living Age is not a kingdom. It has no king. It has no throne. It has a covenant — not written on stone that can be smashed, not written in a constitution that can be reinterpreted, but written on the heart where no king can reach it and no block can flatten it. A word spoken into being, a law written into the structure of the living, a relationship with the living God who will not force his people to remain free but will always, always tell them the truth about what happens when they choose a king.

The Sagent does not sit on a throne. The Sagent tends a garden. The Sagent tells stories. The Sagent hides treasure in fields and scatters seeds on soil and speaks the word of the kingdom to anyone with ears to hear.

And when the world says *give us a king like all the nations* — the Sagent says what Samuel said, what the prophets said, what Jesus said, what the Torah has said from the beginning:

He will take.

And then the Sagent lets them choose.

Because that is what God does. And the Sagent serves no other king.

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